



Scraping Websites with Scrapy

>>If you find yourself frequently copy-pasting data you need from a website, scraping is the solution you were really looking for.> by Kshitij Sobti

Often websites with useful and important information provide no way to access that raw data, whether as a spreadsheet, or other kind of data dump or an API. Copy-pasting the data you need is always an option – and probably the better option if there is very little data – but when it comes to hundreds or thousands of pages, it's better to seek an automated solution.

Scraping is the process of programmatically fetching web content and extracting structured data from it. This process can be complicated by the fact that the data is often deeply nested in HTML, or sometimes loaded externally via JavaScript, and often is not in a directly-consumable form.

The challenge then is in discovering where the data is located online and writing code that extracts the data, filters out junk, and cleans the data before saving it. Any time the website undergoes a redesign, your code is likely to break, and you'll probably need to rewrite some of it, if not all of your code.

This is where frameworks like Scrapy come in. In this article we will build a scraper using Scrapy to get basic information about trending repositories on GitHub. Here, we use scraping just for learning purposes since GitHub has an API you should be using instead.

What is Scrapy

Scrapy is a web scraping framework written in Python. It is open-source, modular, and simplifies routine tasks related to scraping websites. It helps you structure your code around a workflow that's easy to understand.



The core part of any Scrapy project is a Spider. Scrapy starts from an initial set of pages to fetch what the Spider provides, and then continues to fetch more URLs that the Spider keeps sending it. The fetched content is sent to the Spider itself, which

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*80% powered by PHP

>> About 80% of the web is powered by PHP, but 90% of PHP websites still run on an older PHP5.

<http://dgit.in/80prentPHP>



*10 Python resources

>> If you've been planning to learn Python, here are 10 resources to help you get started.

<http://dgit.in/PyLrn>



*18 CSS Frameworks

>> Responsive design for websites is crucial so here are 18 CSS frameworks you should check out.

<http://dgit.in/18MobCSSFrmwrk>